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From self-strengthening to global engagement: a policy review of China's EFL development, 1862–2025

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This paper aims to examine the historical evolution of China's English as a Foreign Language (EFL) policy from 1862 to 2025 and to explain how these policies have been shaped by shifting state priorities, ideological orientations, and China's changing position in the world. Methodologically, the study employs a qualitative historical policy analysis that synthesizes primary documentary sources, including policy documents, regulations, curricular guidelines, examination-related materials, and official public statements, together with relevant secondary scholarship. The analysis is organized chronologically across three periods—the Semi-colonial Period (1862–1949), the Communist Revolution Period (1949–1978), and the Reform and Opening-up Period (1978–2025)—and interpreted through Bernard Spolsky's tripartite model of language policy, focusing on the interaction among language management, language beliefs/ideology, and language practices. Findings show that the development of China's EFL policy has not followed a linear process of educational expansion, but has instead been shaped by the historically contingent interaction among management, ideological beliefs, and educational practice. They further reveal that the role of English shifted from a tool of self-strengthening and foreign knowledge acquisition, to a politically constrained language under socialist and revolutionary priorities, and later to a strategic resource for modernization, global communication, and the international expression of Chinese culture. The study concludes that the effectiveness and durability of EFL policy depend largely on the degree of alignment among language management, beliefs/ideology, and practices. These findings suggest that future EFL policy in China should promote more coherent coordination across assessment, pedagogy, technology, teacher development, and resource distribution, while future research should further examine EFL policy within the broader language-in-education ecology.

KEYWORDS
EFL education in China, English as a foreign language, language beliefs/ideology, language management, language policy, language practice

1 Introduction

National language policy has far-reaching consequences for a country's capacity to participate in regional and global networks. Across the world, state decisions about language(s) in schooling and public life help allocate linguistic resources, shape citizens' language learning trajectories, and influence access to social and economic

mobility. In Asia, rapid modernization and expanding regional and international engagement have made language policy, particularly language-in-education planning, a key instrument through which governments pursue development goals. China offers a particularly salient example: as national priorities and external relations have shifted over time, the role of English in education has been repeatedly reconfigured, tying language planning to broader agendas of modernization and global engagement (Adamson and Morris, 1997).

A national language policy, encompassing linguistic behaviors and perceptions (Spolsky, 2004), is defined as "the deliberate choices made by governments or other authorities with regard to the relationship between language and social life" (Dijite, 1994, p. 63). Its formulation frequently varies "with perceived priorities of national development" (Hu, 2005, p. 6) and is shaped by commercial, geographical, and religious reasons (Küçükoğlu, 2013). Therefore, even though English language education has frequently been associated with modernization, national language policies do vary from country to country, reflecting diverse historical, cultural, and social contexts. These variations demonstrate the efforts of authorities to regulate or influence people's language practices and beliefs (Spolsky, 2009).

In China, national-level EFL policies have become an integral component of the country's educational system and national development strategy. Against this backdrop, this paper offers a longitudinal analysis of the development of EFL policy in China from 1862 to 2025 across three periods: the Semi-colonial Period (1862–1949), the Communist Revolution Period (1949–1978), and the Reform and Opening-up Period (1978–2025). By examining these periods, the paper aims to highlight how China's EFL policies have adapted to shifting national priorities and global positioning.

2 Literature review

2.1 Historiography of EFL education in China

Existing scholarship widely acknowledges that the development of EFL education in China exhibits clear stage-specific characteristics. Most studies adopt a historical periodization approach, using major political events as turning points to explain the trajectory of foreign language education. One of the earliest systematic accounts is provided by Fu (1986) in *A History of Foreign Language Education in China*, which traces foreign language education from early encounters with Western languages before 1840 through the modernization efforts of the late Qing and Republican periods, and eventually to the institutional development of English education in the People's Republic of China (PRC). Building upon this historiographical foundation, subsequent scholars have proposed more refined periodizations of EFL development.

Rao (2013), for instance, divides the development of EFL teaching into five stages: the pre-liberation period (before 1949), the early socialist period (1949–1956), the first revival period (1956–1966), the Cultural Revolution period (1966–1977), and the second revival period following the reform and opening-up (after 1977). Similarly, Adamson (2004) identifies five phases in post-1949 English education: the Soviet influence period (1949–1960), the period toward educational quality (1961–1966), the Cultural Revolution period (1966–1976), the modernization period under Deng Xiaoping (1977–1993), and the globalization integration period after 1993. Hu Wenzhong proposes a broader tripartite division, consisting of the institutional formation period (1949–1965), the disruption period during the Cultural Revolution (1966–1977), and the recovery and development period following the reform and opening-up (1978–2009).

Taken together, these studies reveal a consistent pattern in which the trajectory of English education closely mirrors shifts in national political priorities. During the early years of the PRC and particularly during the Cultural Revolution, English was frequently labeled an "imperialist language", which led to a significant decline in its institutional status and teaching presence. By contrast, the reform and opening-up policy dramatically elevated the status of English, as China sought deeper integration into the global economic system. In this sense, EFL education in China has never functioned merely as a neutral linguistic tool; rather, it has consistently embodied broader ideological, political, and cultural meanings (Pan, 2015). Over time, its role has gradually expanded from a primarily instrumental function toward one that also encompasses intercultural communication and global competence.

Despite differences in specific periodization schemes, existing historiographical studies share a common analytical assumption: that the development of EFL education in China is fundamentally shaped by the interaction between language policy and national development agendas.

2.2 Theoretical interpretations of EFL policy change

While early historical studies primarily documented policy changes and institutional developments, more recent scholarship has increasingly attempted to explain the mechanisms underlying these transformations. This shift reflects a broader transition in the field from descriptive historiography toward theoretically informed policy analysis. More broadly, language policy scholarship has emphasized that policy is not confined to official state documents, but operates through the interaction of ideology, institutional management, and everyday practice (e.g., Johnson, 2009; Kaplan and Baldauf, 1997; Ricento, 2006; Shohamy, 2006). These perspectives have also highlighted how curricula, textbooks, and examinations function as important sites through which policy is interpreted, mediated, and enacted.

Adamson (2004) makes an important contribution by bringing curriculum analysis into the historical study of EFL education in China. With a particular focus on official syllabi and textbooks, the study demonstrates how the state constructed an "official English" through a process of "selective assimilation", in which foreign linguistic and cultural influences were filtered rather than simply accepted or rejected. English education in China is compared to a "sluice gate": when political tensions intensified, the gate narrowed and tighter ideological control was imposed; when modernization and international engagement were prioritized, the gate opened wider and English assumed a more prominent place in the curriculum.

Building upon this interpretation, Hu (2005) further interprets the expansion of English education through the lens of economic pragmatism. In his view, the promotion of English has been closely associated with China's efforts to facilitate international trade, technological exchange, and global communication. Cao (2019) examines EFL policy fluctuations through the framework of national interest, arguing that changes in English education policy often reflect shifting political and economic priorities rather than a stable long-term educational strategy. Pan's (2015) ideological perspective complements these analyses by highlighting that policy decisions are also shaped by broader cultural and identity considerations, not solely by pragmatic or economic concerns.

Related scholarship has further situated these developments within wider debates on globalization, multilingualism, and language ideology (e.g., Bolton and Graddol, 2012; Hamid et al., 2013; Pan, 2015). As part of this broader shift, recent research on self-regulated language learning (SRLL) through language-learning applications also indicates that contemporary EFL policy is mediated by digitally supported learning practices, as app use is shaped by the interaction among design affordances, learner expectations, and wider policy or market ecologies (Lo and Chang, 2025). Additionally, institutional practices supporting teacher well-being, such as Positive Psychology (PP) interventions, have gained increasing attention in the evolving educational landscape. These practices have become an integral part of contemporary EFL policy, further shaping both teacher resilience and the classroom climate (Lo and Punzalan, 2025).

A broader regional perspective also helps contextualize the relationship between English and modernization in China. Research on Japan and South Korea has shown that the expansion of English education across East Asia has often been tied to state-led modernization, internationalization, and shifting constructions of national identity, while also generating tensions around cultural sovereignty, inequality, and educational pressure (e.g., Kubota, 1998; Park, 2009; Seargeant, 2009). Recent syntheses of English-medium instruction (EMI) likewise suggest that English in Asian education must be understood not only as an instrumental resource, but also as part of broader debates about competitiveness, social stratification, and language ideology (Hamid et al., 2013; Wang and Kirkpatrick, 2013).

Together, these studies illustrate an important shift in the research field: the study of EFL policy in China has gradually moved from descriptive documentation toward explanatory analysis that seeks to uncover the ideological, political, and economic logics underlying policy transformations.

2.3 Limitations in existing scholarship and the contribution of the present study

First, many studies are constrained by relatively narrow historical scopes. Most classic periodizations begin with the founding of the PRC in 1949, paying insufficient attention to the formative role of EFL education during the late Qing and Republican periods. As a result, the deeper historical roots and institutional continuities of EFL policy remain underexplored.

Second, existing research has not sufficiently incorporated emerging transformations in the contemporary educational landscape. In the twenty-first century, the ecology of EFL education in China has been reshaped by multiple forces, including the rapid development of artificial intelligence in language learning, structural changes in higher education, and renewed debates surrounding globalization and cultural identity.

Third, theoretical integration in the field remains limited. Existing studies on the history of EFL policy in China have generated valuable descriptive accounts of policy change across different periods, but many remain primarily historical or documentary in orientation, focusing on policy chronology rather than on the underlying mechanisms driving change. Even when explanations are offered, they are often framed broadly in terms of national needs, state interests, or political context, without systematically examining how policy evolved through the interaction among language management, language beliefs/ideology, and language practices, or how these dynamics were mediated through curriculum, assessment and institutional implementation.

In response to these gaps, the present study contributes to the literature in two major ways: it extends the temporal scope of EFL policy analysis by tracing the origins of modern English education in China back to 1862, thereby incorporating the late Qing and Republican periods into the historical narrative; and it systematically applies Bernard Spolsky's three-component model of language policy to a diachronic analysis of China's EFL policy development, with the aim of explaining how the evolving ideology of modernization and global engagement has shaped the interaction among policy, ideology, and educational practice across different historical periods.

3 Theoretical framework

3.1 Spolsky's tripartite model of language policy

This study adopts Bernard Spolsky's Tripartite Model of Language Policy as its analytical framework. Spolsky (2004, 2017) contends that language policy is not limited to official regulations or decrees but rather is a system comprising three interrelated components: language management, language beliefs/ideology, and language practices. According to the model, language management refers to deliberate interventions by authorities, such as educational reforms, curricula, and examinations; language beliefs or ideology refer to the values and attitudes attached to languages; and language practices refer to the actual use of language in social domains. Taken together, these three dimensions provide a dynamic lens for examining the interplay among state regulation, societal attitudes, and linguistic behavior.

3.2 Terminological clarification and application of the framework

Although Spolsky employs the phrase "language beliefs or ideology", this study uses the two terms in a differentiated way according to the level of analysis. Beliefs is used to refer to people's values, attitudes, and evaluative judgments about language and language use, whereas ideology is used when discussing broader state-centered or politically institutionalized

systems of thought, especially those related to power, legitimacy, and national goals.

By employing Spolsky's model in this way, this study examines China's EFL policy from 1862 to 2025 through a historical perspective. The analysis uses time as its narrative thread to illustrate the distinctive features of policy development across different periods. It further interprets these changes through the three interrelated dimensions of language practices, beliefs or ideology, and management. Through this framework, the study seeks to show how English education in China has evolved in relation to broader national development strategies, shifting political priorities, and changing social perceptions of English.

3.3 Methodological approach

This article adopts a historical and interpretive literature-based approach. It synthesizes primary sources, including Ministry of Education policy documents, regulations, curricular guidelines, examination-related materials, and official statements where available, together with relevant secondary scholarship (peer-reviewed articles and monographs, 1980–2025, in Chinese and English) from CNKI, Web of Science, and Google Scholar. The analysis proceeds chronologically, using major historical periods as the narrative structure, and applies Spolsky's three components as analytical categories to interpret policy shifts across time. Following Spolsky (2004, 2009), language practices refer to observable patterns of language use and implementation; language beliefs/ideology refer to the articulated rationales behind policy decisions as expressed in official discourse; and language management refers to formal interventions by state or institutional actors (e.g., curriculum regulation, examination reforms, program approval decisions). Rather than assigning each policy document wholesale to a single category, the analysis coded specific policy provisions, discursive statements, and reported practices according to the component(s) they most clearly exemplified. Shifts in beliefs/ideology were inferred from recurring evaluative and justificatory discourse in policy prefaces, curriculum standards, ministerial speeches, and related Party-state documents, especially where these texts articulated the political, cultural, educational, or developmental purposes of EFL education. All Chinese sources were translated by the author; translations of key policy documents were cross-checked against authoritative English versions where available. Recent claims (e.g., CET format changes, English program closures) were verified against original official announcements and authoritative media coverage. A compact appendix listing the main MOE and state policy documents by year, with links, is provided to enhance transparency.

4 The semi-colonial period (1862–1949)

4.1 The beginning of modernity (1862–1912)

Introduced by British missionaries, EFL education in China commenced at the beginning of the 19th century (Chen, 2013). In the mid-19th century, China's defeats in the Anglo-Chinese Opium Wars (1839–42 and 1856–60) led to the signing of unequal treaties with European powers and the United States (Scott, 2008). The unprecedented national humiliation prompted the Qing Dynasty's government to adopt Western technology, initiating the Self-Strengthening Movement (Chang, 2017; Zeng and Wang, 2019; Zhao, 2019), which was a series of radical institutional, military, diplomatic, fiscal and educational reforms. Prince Gong, a leader of the Self-Strengthening Movement and a diplomat overseeing foreign affairs, penned a memorial to Tongzhi, the emperor of the Qing Dynasty, advocating for the establishment of a foreign language school in Beijing. He asserted, "Understanding foreign countries is essential when negotiating with them", and "grasping foreign languages is crucial to this understanding, thereby preventing deceit by Western powers"[1] (Li, 2008, p. 342). In this memorial, Prince Gong recommended John Shaw Burdon, a missionary, to spearhead the establishment of the language school. Meanwhile, he covertly recommended that John Shaw Burdon be overseen by a Chinese tutor to prevent him from engaging in missionary work while teaching (Li, 2008). This initiative signified the inception of official formal EFL education in China.

In 1862, the Imperial Tung Wen College, China's first official foreign language school, was established, enrolling ten EFL learners from upper-class families. Historically, this marked the beginning of standardized English education managed by the Chinese government (Fu, 1986). The college's EFL curriculum emphasized the translation of notes, official documents, and books. After passing highly-competitive tests, students were offered governmental positions (Fu, 1986). Subsequently, additional foreign language schools were gradually established. The coerced establishment of treaty ports in coastal areas, coupled with growing trade exchanges, heightened the need for foreign language education. Consequently, foreign language schools were established in coastal cities and along the Yangtze River, including the Shanghai Multi-language School (1863), Guangzhou Tung Wen College (1864), and Hubei Self-improvement School (Zhao, 2019).[2] Beyond language education, these schools also designed courses in Western science, technology, history, and geography. The teaching objective was to encourage students to read and translate Western books, thereby fostering Western learning (Shu, 1961). The Self-Strengthening Movement lasted for 34 years, during which time EFL policies sought to achieve three objectives: diplomacy, self-strengthening, and trade.

In 1894, the Qing government faced a devastating defeat in the First Sino-Japanese War. This critical defeat served as a profound shock to China, showcasing the Meiji Restorations' success in transforming Japan into a dominant power, thereby supplanting China's pivotal role in East Asia (Gordon, 2019). Subsequently, the Self-Strengthening Movement came to an end, giving rise to a

[1]This memorial was compiled by Li Shuyuan from the Editorial Department of Chinese Books Company, with quotations translated by the author of this research.

[2]Subsequently, these foreign language schools expanded their curricula to include additional language courses such as Russian, German, French and Japanese. However, given the scope of this study is specifically concentrated on policies pertaining to EFL, the discussion of other foreign languages falls outside the purview of this overview.

group of prominent Kang-Liang reformers[3] who believed that China could never be strong or independent without fundamentally reforming its traditional political system, and who thus started the Modernization Movement (Li and Ren, 2012). In 1904, aiming to glean insights from Japan's educational reform (Guo, 1999), the Qing government introduced the *1903 School System*, stipulating that foreign language courses be set up from the middle school level (Fu, 1986). Guided by Zhang Zhidong's philosophy of *Zhong Ti Xi Yong*[4]—meaning Confucianism underpins the core system and science directs the techniques (Zhou, 2022)—reformist-established translation schools persisted in emphasizing Chinese language and literature education alongside foreign language instruction (Fu, 1986). This approach illustrated the reformers' sensitivity to preserving Chinese national identity in the process of Western learning, thereby laying the foundation for the instrumental outlook on foreign language pedagogy.

4.2 The republican Era (1912–1949)

The 1911 Revolution led to the overthrow of the Qing Dynasty, resulting in the establishment of the Republic of China under the leadership of the Kuomintang (KMT). In 1912, drawing on the disciplines, teaching materials, and methods of the American educational system (Fu, 1986; Liu, 2015; Zhu, 2010), the KMT promulgated the *New School System*, mandating English courses from middle school (Li, 2012). In 1913, the Ministry of Education of the Republic of China issued *University Regulations*, clearly outlining provisions for English major courses that encompassed British and Chinese literature, history, and philosophy (Chen, 2013). University EFL curricula were shaped by the prevailing British and American literary traditions, emphasizing classical literature and history while overlooking the communicative use of the English language (Fu, 1986). In 1916, the *Rules for the Implementation of Higher Primary Schools* mandated the introduction of English course in higher primary schools, enabling children to attain a basic understanding and use of the foreign language (Meng, 2012). Moreover, the adoption of the *Outline of Foreign Language Curriculum for Junior Middle Schools (1923)* and *Senior High Schools (1923)* along with the *Interim English Curriculum Standards for Junior and Senior Middle Schools (1929)*, further institutionalized and popularized English education (Li, 2012). During the same period, from 1912 to 1949, English emerged as the predominant foreign language course (Li, 2012), with schools having the autonomy to design their curricula and select teaching materials (Liu, 2015; Zhu, 2010).

During the Semi-colonial Period, EFL policies formally integrated English into the Chinese education curriculum. Additionally, both the Qing government and the KMT not only tolerated church-run schools[5] but also actively supported study-abroad programs, significantly contributing to the advancement of English education in China (Li, 2009; Xu, 2013). Regrettably, the frequent occurrence of foreign and civil wars during this period led to intermittent losses of China's sovereignty and territorial integrity. With China's disintegration and weakening, school enrollment numbers for children drastically declined. As a result, the population of EFL learners during this era was markedly low, and there was also a critical shortage of qualified English language teachers, which severely hampered efforts to improve English proficiency across the nation. Consequently, during the Semi-colonial Period, the scale of English education in primary and secondary schools was limited. EFL education was predominantly theoretical, manifesting mainly through policies, as only children of the upper class in coastal cities were afforded the opportunity to study English (Fu, 1986). In essence, during this era, EFL policies conferred advantages exclusively on a minority within the elite class.

From Spolsky's perspective, the semi-colonial period reveals the interaction of language management, beliefs/ideology, and practices in the early development of EFL education in China. At the level of management, both the Qing government and the Republican state increasingly incorporated English into official schooling through foreign language schools, curriculum regulations, and examination arrangements. At the level of beliefs, English was valued primarily as an instrumental means of diplomacy, trade, national strengthening, and access to modern knowledge, rather than as a vehicle for cultural assimilation. In practice, however, English learning remained limited in scale, largely translation-oriented, and accessible mainly to urban upper-class students. This period therefore established the policy legitimacy of English in modern Chinese education, while also revealing a persistent gap between policy expansion and broad social access.

5 The communist revolution period (1949–1978)

5.1 The early PRC (1949–1955)

In 1949, the Chinese Communist Party (CCP) ousted the KMT government, culminating in the establishment of the People's Republic of China (PRC). For Mao Zedong, the

[3]Kiang-Liang denotes the partnership of Kang Youwei and Liang Qichao, who led a group of 603 civil service examination candidates to write a memorial to the Emperor Guangxu for urging reforms modeled on Western practices.

[4]Zhang Zhidong, a prominent official in the late Qing Dynasty, is renowned for his *Zhong Ti Xi Yong* ideology, which posits that China's salvation hinges on the adoption of Western technologies while retaining the Chinese traditional system. This philosophy exerted a significant impact on educational reforms from the late Qing Dynasty through to the early Republic of China. For instance, Yenching University, which later evolved into Peking University, upheld Zhang Zhidong's principles by emphasizing the practical utility of foreign languages. It championed the harmonious integration of traditional and contemporary knowledge, underscoring the importance of both Chinese and Western academic disciplines.

[5]Church-affiliated schools, registered abroad, played a dual role in China by disseminating Christianity and making notable contributions to English education. St. John's University, for example, was instrumental in producing numerous diplomats and translators for China. Officially, Chinese educational policy maintained a cautious stance towards missionary activities. Yet, the turbulence of continuous conflicts during the Semi-colonial Period left the government preoccupied, unable to closely regulate private education. This oversight inadvertently fostered a more liberal environment for private English education ventures, particularly those operated by foreign church organizations, allowing them to flourish.

paramount leader of the CCP, nationalism and "contradiction" (Nolan, 1990, p. 160) were fundamental, asserting to the international community that China would no longer tolerate being demeaned (Rosenberg, 2011). Mao regarded the socialist economy as fundamentally opposed to capitalism, terming it "the antithesis of capitalism" (Nolan, 1990, p. 160). Despite achieving civil peace in 1949, China continued to be characterized by its agrarian economy and widespread poverty. Faced with myriad challenges, including the aftermath of successive wars, Chairman Mao resolved to emulate the Soviet Union by adopting its planned economic system (Mao, 2008). In 1950, the signing of the *Treaty on Friendship, Union and Mutual Assistance* between the Soviet Union and China marked the beginning of substantial Soviet support for China's nascent industrialization efforts (Yu, 2017). Simultaneously, under the predominant influence by Leninist-Stalinist Marxism of the Soviet Union and Mao's ideologies, the Chinese government endeavored to standardize the education system.

Influenced by the strong ties with the Soviet Union, China prioritized Russian language instruction at both middle school and higher education levels from 1949 to 1956, a time characterized by the widespread slogans "Learn from the Soviet Union comprehensively" and "The Soviet Union's today is our tomorrow". This era saw a rapid advancement of Russian language education in China (Li, 2009, p. 83–84). Concurrently, English education was significantly marginalized, overshadowed by the Russian language's ascendancy, leading to a dramatic career shift for many EFL teachers in the early 1950s (Fu, 1986). The number of universities offering EFL courses dwindled from 64 during the KMT era to just 8 by 1952 (Dai, 2008). Further diminishing the role of English, in April 1954, the Ministry of Education (MOE) issued directives that effectively halted the establishment of English language courses in junior middle schools, reducing the autonomy of schools in providing EFL education (Hu, 2005). The dominance of Russian educational models was so pervasive that even English language curricula, teaching methodologies, and resources were crafted to mirror Soviet standards, resulting in a disjointed approach to the study of English phonics, grammar, and vocabulary (Fu, 1986).

By the mid to late 1950s, the Sino-Soviet split became apparent as China chose not to align itself under Soviet leadership within the international Communist movement, significantly affecting Russian language education within the country (Yu, 2017). By 1956, the production of Russian language experts far surpassed the demand within China's job market (Zuo and Gong, 2021). Concurrently, high-ranking CCP officials criticized the unwavering adoption of Soviet models and acknowledged the detrimental effects of diminishing EFL education on China's foreign diplomatic capabilities (Fu, 1986). In that pivotal year, Premier Zhou Enlai emphasized the critical need for EFL education and the translation of foreign texts in his *Report on the Intellectuals' Issues* (Zhou, 1984a, p. 186). Motivated by Zhou's insights, on July 10, 1956, the MOE mandated the introduction of English courses from the first year of high school in regions with adequate teaching resources starting that fall, and from the fall of 1957, English courses were to be reintroduced from the first year of junior high school, assigning a provisional four hours of weekly instruction (MOE, 1956).

The 1956 policy reversed the previous suspension of English courses from 1954, addressing the oversight of EFL instruction since the inception of the People's Republic of China. Efforts to rejuvenate EFL education were evident with the issuance of the *Senior High School English Syllabus (Draft)* in 1956 and the *Junior High School English Syllabus (Draft)* in 1957, both of which elevated English to a major subject status (Li, 2009, p. 99). Consequently, the number of universities offering English courses rose to 23 by the end of that year (Fu, 1986; Hu, 2009). These initiatives aimed to reinvigorate EFL education at the secondary level in large and medium-sized cities. However, the ambitious plans for these EFL policies were ultimately undermined by the Anti-rightist Movement in 1957 and the Educational Reform in 1958, which criticized foreign language education for its perceived detachment from political and revolutionary ideals (Fu, 1986).

In 1959, the MOE issued *A Notice on Strengthening Foreign Language Education in Middle Schools*, with a specific focus on expanding English education while reducing the emphasis on Russian (Liu, 2008). Echoing Premier Zhou Enlai's belief that childhood represents the optimal period for learning a foreign language (Zhou, 1984b), primary and secondary schools across China's major cities began introducing English courses at the primary level 3 or the first year of junior middle school (Qin, 2001). Premier Zhou, further underlining the importance of foreign language education following his 1964 diplomatic tour of 14 countries across Asia, Africa, and Europe, led to the creation of the *Outline of the Seven-year Plan for Foreign Language Education* in October 1964. This plan not only prioritized English as the primary foreign language but also led to the establishment of numerous foreign language schools (HERC, 1993). The initiative also supported out-of-school English education, including night classes and broadcasts on radio and television, and laid plans for sending Chinese students abroad for English studies (HERC, 1993).

5.2 The cultural revolution (1966–1976)

Unfortunately, the political upheavals from 1966 to 1976 hindered the effective implementation of the *Seven-year Plan*, significantly impacting the development of EFL education in China. The Cultural Revolution, initiated by Mao Zedong in 1966, plunged EFL education into a crisis of near collapse between 1966 and 1970, characterized by a "political movement of ideological extremism" (Hu, 2005, p. 7). Accusations from narrow-minded nationalists branded foreign staff as adversaries of Socialism, encapsulated in the sentiment, "One can do revolution without learning ABC" (Fu, 1986, p. 82; Zeng and Wang, 2019, p. 93). This period saw the populace isolated from foreign literary works, newspapers, radio, and films, effectively severing any exposure to foreign cultures (Fu, 1986). Additionally, many educators, suspected of being foreign agents, were dismissed from their positions, further debilitating the landscape of EFL education (Hu, 2009).

In 1971, the People's Republic of China's entry into the United Nations heralded a new era of international engagement (Hook, 1974). The subsequent year saw the Sino–US Shanghai Communiqué, jointly issued with the United States, marking a significant thaw in decades of bilateral hostility (Worden, 1979; Westad, 2005). This breakthrough paved the way for the revitalization of EFL education in China, leading to the

re-enrollment of students in foreign language schools and the recruitment of foreign educators. Despite this progress, the prevailing atmosphere of apprehension, a legacy of the Cultural Revolution's extremism, deterred ordinary Chinese from interacting with foreign teachers, as the regime continued to prioritize "political standards first", limiting educational content to Maoist doctrine and political texts (Fu, 1986, p. 85). Consequently, many EFL students' initial exposure to English was politically charged phrases like "Long live Chairman Mao" (Lu, 2017, p. 320). Teaching materials were laden with political slogans, and the educational process remained under the strict surveillance of workers, peasants, and soldiers, reflecting the period's politicized approach to education (Fu, 1986).

During the Communist Revolution Period, the advancement of English education was significantly hindered as political ideology overshadowed educational expertise. Despite the setbacks in the implementation of EFL policies, due to domestic political upheavals, there were noteworthy theoretical aspects within these policies that merit closer examination. The *Outline of the Seven-year Plan for Foreign Language Education*, for instance, underscored the dual importance of enhancing proficiency in both foreign languages and Chinese, advocating for an understanding of foreign cultures and thought processes (HERC, 1993). This policy mirrored the Semi-colonial Period's *Zhong Ti Xi Yong* principle by incorporating intercultural elements into language learning. Additionally, certain policies recommended that educators adapt their teaching strategies to suit the specific characteristics of Chinese EFL students and to foster learner autonomy (Fu, 1986), paving the way for the adoption of a more student-centered approach to teaching.

The development of EFL education in this period reveals a close interaction between policy management, language ideology, and actual educational practice. Foreign language policy shifted repeatedly with changes in diplomatic alignment and political campaigns, from the prioritization of Russian to the partial restoration of English and then to severe disruption during the Cultural Revolution. English was evaluated less in pedagogical terms than in ideological and geopolitical terms, so that it could be treated either as politically suspect or as strategically necessary. In practice, English learning remained unstable, heavily politicized, and often disconnected from communicative use, although the late 1950s and early 1960s also saw tentative efforts to broaden access and improve quality.

6 The reform and opening-up period (1978–2025)

6.1 The revival period (1978–1989)

Following the tumultuous Cultural Revolution, Deng Xiaoping emerged as China's paramount leader in 1978, marking a pivotal shift in the nation's direction. Deng embarked on a journey to revitalize China's economy through the introduction of market mechanisms and an openness to Western influences, heralding the era of Reform and Opening-up (Albers and Chen, 2017; Li and Zeng, 2021). With a firm belief in the transformative power of science and technology for China's modernization (Deng, 1994), Deng prioritized English language education in the early stages of these reforms. Under his guidance, utilitarian principles shaped national development strategies and educational policies, positioning English as a vital tool for economic growth. EFL education became integral to absorbing advanced scientific, technological, and enterprise management knowledge from the developed world (Dai and Hu, 2009; Hu, 2005; Zeng and Wang, 2019), reflecting its newfound role in China's ambitious modernization efforts.

Reflecting on the setbacks faced by EFL education during the Cultural Revolution, in 1979, Shanghai International Studies University (SISU) issued the *Suggestions on Strengthening Foreign Language Education*. This pivotal document underscored the necessity of aligning English education with the goals of scientific and technological progress (SISU, 1978). Garnering approval from the State Council in 1979, these recommendations were disseminated across educational institutions, serving as a strategic blueprint to augment English instruction, enhance the training of EFL educators, and foster research in teaching methodologies and linguistics (Zeng and Wang, 2019). In a significant move towards depoliticizing language education, 1980 witnessed the removal of leftist ideological phrases such as "international class struggle" and "revolutionary diplomacy" from English curricula, marking a clear departure from the politically charged content of the past (Fu, 1986).

The aftermath of the Cultural Revolution presented a significant challenge to the implementation of EFL policies during Deng Xiaoping's leadership, primarily due to a severe shortage of professional EFL teachers. In response to this crisis, the early 1980s saw the recruitment of many inexperienced individuals who had acquired their English language skills through radio or television programs into the teaching workforce. To address this issue, the MOE initiated the *Three-year College English Teachers Training Program from 1980 to 1983*, which contributed to a notable increase in the number of secondary school English teachers to approximately 70,000 by the period between 1985 and 1990. Additionally, the number of tertiary institutions offering pre-service English language teacher education programs expanded from 161 in 1981 to 226 in 1989. Despite these efforts, the professional competence of EFL teachers during this era remained critically low. A survey from the mid-1980s revealed that 69% of English teachers in key schools had not received any professional training, and by 1988, only 26% of high school EFL teachers possessed professional qualifications, underscoring the ongoing challenge of improving teaching standards in EFL education (Hu, 2005).

In the 1980s, Deng Xiaoping's approach to education, influenced by the limitations of educational resources, prioritized efficiency and stratification over equity, as noted by Tsang (2000). This strategy led to a significant role for foreign language schools, particularly those considered elite institutions in major cities, in spearheading the development of English education (Hu, 2005). A notable example of this stratification occurred in 1982 when the MOE crafted a specific English syllabus for six prestigious schools (Lewin et al., 1994). Concurrently, the Reform and Opening-up policies exacerbated regional disparities in economic growth, resulting in uneven progress in EFL education across different areas (Hao, 2015; Hu, 2005). The shift towards a market-oriented economy further prompted a move towards autonomy and decentralization within the education sector (Chinese Communist Party Central Committee, 1985), allowing economically prosperous provinces and centrally-administered municipalities to tailor primary and

secondary education to their specific needs from 1985 onwards. This included the creation of local English curriculums, syllabuses, and textbooks (Hu, 2002). In 1988, Shanghai established its local Curriculum and Teaching Materials Reform Commission (CTMRC), pioneering the expansion of EFL education to earlier grades in primary school (starting from Primary 5 down to Primary 1) and adopting content-based English instruction methods (Hu, 2005).

While the 1980s saw targeted efforts towards secondary education and elite schools, tertiary English education also saw marked improvements following its neglect during the Cultural Revolution. The MOE took significant steps to revitalize English learning at the university level, beginning with the publication of the *Public English Syllabus for Science and Engineering Undergraduates* in 1980, which was updated in 1985, and followed by the introduction of *the College English Syllabus for Arts and Science Undergraduates* in 1986. These syllabuses laid the groundwork for a structured approach to EFL education across various academic disciplines. Additionally, the implementation of the College English Test-4 (CET-4) in 1986 and the College English Test-6 (CET-6) in 1987 further underscored this commitment to enhancing English proficiency among university students. These exams became a significant milestone in the standardization and assessment of English language skills at the tertiary level.

6.2 The flourishing period (1989–2012)

During the Reform and Opening-up Period, the foundations of China's modern English education system were consolidated through a series of EFL policies. In addition, government-sponsored overseas programs in the 1980s introduced cultural communication theories to China (Zhang, 2007), helping lay the groundwork for the stronger integration of cultural understanding into EFL policy in the 1990s. This initiative enabled Chinese scholars to explore the intricate interplay between language learning and cultural pedagogy. Such scholarly pursuits laid the groundwork for a significant cultural movement within EFL policies that emerged in the 1990s, marking a shift towards integrating cultural understanding with language education.

In the last decade of the 20th century, China experienced significant economic growth and made concerted efforts to align with the international evolution of EFL education, recognizing quality education as essential for national competitiveness in the era of globalization (CCP Central Committee & State Council, 1993; Hu, 2005). This period saw a heightened focus on English proficiency within the broader framework of quality education, leading to the revision of national secondary English syllabuses in 1992, 1993, and 1996. These revisions aimed to bolster communicative competence and foster learner autonomy (CTMRI, 2001). Beyond the acquisition of scientific, technological, and management knowledge, EFL policies began to incorporate cultural pedagogy and the international promotion of Chinese culture. Notably, the 1998 *Opinions on the Reform of Foreign Language Majors in Undergraduate Education* encouraged learners to critically engage with foreign cultures while disseminating Chinese cultural values. Additionally, the 1999 revision of the *College English Syllabus* underscored the importance of enhancing learners' cultural competence, reflecting a comprehensive approach to EFL education that values both linguistic proficiency and cultural understanding (Dai and Hu, 2009).

The 1990s marked the emergence of numerous privately-owned English training institutions in China, such as New Oriental English School, EF Education, and Crazy English School, several of which later achieved listings in the United States in the 21st century (Zhang, 2014). The burgeoning success of these entities can be attributed to a triad of factors. Firstly, the decade of the 1990s solidified English's status as a core subject within various domestic talent-selection examinations, establishing it as an invaluable personal asset within Chinese society (Adamson, 2001; Cortazzi and Jin, 1996; Jin and Cortazzi, 2002). The demand for EFL learning soared as it was increasingly regarded as a significant form of "linguistic capital" capable of influencing social hierarchies (Simie and Mckinley, 2025). Secondly, an increasing number of Chinese individuals engaged with international English examinations for academic or business purposes in English-speaking nations (Zeng and Wang, 2019), highlighting a gap between the offerings of formal educational institutions and the actual needs of EFL learners. Lastly, the era's socialist market economy maintained lenient regulations concerning private English language training providers, facilitating their rapid growth and proliferation.

Since 2001, EFL education at the primary level in China has experienced exceptional growth, heralded by the MOE's issuance of the *Guidance on Actively Promoting English Education in Primary Schools*. This initiative marked the first time English courses at the primary level were formally integrated into the broader agenda of educational reform in China. Despite this progress, a notable hurdle persisted: the acute shortage of qualified primary EFL teachers, particularly pronounced in less developed regions. To address this gap, the 2001 Guidance proposed an innovative job transfer training project, enabling teachers of non-English subjects with a basic understanding of English to transition into English teaching roles. This strategy led to a significant shift in rural primary education, where, by 2003, it became commonplace for teachers, such as those specializing in math, arts, or music, to also undertake English instruction, marking a pivotal step towards broadening access to EFL education across diverse geographic areas.

At the dawn of the 21st century, significant events such as China's accession to the World Trade Organization and its successful bid to host the 2008 Olympic Games played pivotal roles in elevating the status of EFL education within the country. Recognizing the limitations of relying exclusively on economic, scientific, and technological advancements for global competitiveness, the Chinese government shifted its focus towards leveraging soft power (Ding, 2012). Between 2000 and 2010, this shift was reflected in the implementation of EFL policies aimed at refining and systematizing the approach to language education, emphasizing humanistic and intercultural perspectives. Notably, the *General Senior High School Curriculum Standards* issued in 2003 underscored the importance of addressing EFL learners' emotional needs, learning strategies, and cross-cultural awareness (MOE, 2003). Concurrently, the *Syllabus for English Majors in Colleges and Universities (2000)* advocated for the development of learners' sensitivity, tolerance, and adaptability in cultural exchanges, including the promotion of

Chinese culture (MOE, 2001). Furthermore, the *Teaching Requirements of College English Courses (2007)* outlined that college-level English instruction should encompass both instrumental objectives and humanistic values (Dai and Hu, 2009), marking a comprehensive effort to enhance EFL education in alignment with global engagement and cultural diplomacy.

By the conclusion of this period, EFL policies had increasingly aligned with the global shift toward student-centered education. In both pedagogical practices and underlying beliefs, teachers were reconceptualized as active designers, participants, and collaborators in the learning process, with policies mandating sensitivity to diverse learner needs. Simultaneously, EFL teacher development was given equal priority, as initiatives promoted the teacher–researcher model and the principle of lifelong learning within institutional frameworks (Xu, 2016). These dual emphases fostered a symbiotic dynamic of growth for both EFL teachers and learners. In sum, China's EFL policies became deeply internalized across nearly every dimension and systematically institutionalized at all levels of education. Table 1 presents the key policy documents that constitute this current national framework, with full bibliographic details provided in the reference list.

6.3 The global engagement period (2012–2025)

The socioeconomic reforms initiated by the Chinese government have led to significant national prosperity, propelling China to become the world's second-largest economy by 2010 (Haini, 2021). Despite this achievement, there was a perception that China's voice in international cultural communication remained disproportionately weak compared to its economic stature (Ding, 2012; Sun, 2020). President Xi Jinping's advocacy for "culture self-confidence", "strengthening moral education", "improving China's international discursive power", establishing a "consciousness of national security", and constructing a "community with a shared future for mankind" have infused EFL policies with a more explicit political dimension (Xi, 2016a, b, 2017, 2018). In this context, English has increasingly been positioned not only as a tool for intercultural communication, but also a means of presenting China to the outside world. Contemporary EFL policies continue to emphasize intercultural competence while also encouraging the development of students' cultural identity and their ability to communicate aspects of Chinese culture through English. Both the compulsory education and senior high school English curriculum standards identify language proficiency, cultural awareness, critical thinking, and learning skills as the four foundational competencies to be developed through EFL education, with a particular emphasis on cultural awareness as a pathway to cultural confidence (MOE, 2020b; MOE, 2022a). Consequently, under Xi's leadership, EFL policies have evolved to embody attributes that are not only instrumental and humanistic but also increasingly political, especially in relation to cultural confidence, national identity and international communication.

TABLE 1. Key policy documents constituting the current national framework of EFL education in China.

Educational stage	Key policy document	Scope	Year
Primary School	English Curriculum Standards for Compulsory Education	Grades 1–5	2022
Junior High School		Grades 6–9	2022
Senior High School	General Senior High School English Curriculum Standards	Grades 10–12	(2017 Edition; 2020 Revision)
University (General English)	College English Teaching Guidelines	Non-English Major Undergraduates	2020
University (English Major)	Guidelines for English Majors	English Major Undergraduates	2020

These policy documents are issued by different bodies within the Ministry of Education of the People's Republic of China. General curriculum standards are issued directly by the Ministry of Education, while policies for non-English-major undergraduates and English-major undergraduates are issued by the relevant national teaching advisory bodies. The English Curriculum Standards for Compulsory Education apply to both primary and junior high school stages, with differentiated requirements for each.

The College English Teaching Guidelines issued by the MOE in 2016 underscored the importance of English learning in enhancing China's linguistic capabilities, facilitating the global dissemination of Chinese culture, and bolstering the nation's soft power (MOE, 2016). Subsequently, the 2017 edition of the *General Senior High School Curriculum Standards* emphasized the necessity of acknowledging and integrating the nuances of Chinese and foreign cultures (MOE, 2017). It advocated for a correct understanding and appreciation of other cultures, the active development of cross-cultural communication skills, and the promotion of national identity and cultural confidence in order to spread and enhance the socialist culture with Chinese characteristics. Further emphasizing this direction, *Guidelines for English Majors (2020)* outlined that the core curriculum should encompass courses on the *History of Western Civilization* and *An Introduction to Chinese Culture*, aiming to cultivate both an international outlook and a sense of patriotism among English majors (MOE, 2020c). In a significant move in 2022, the MOE updated the *English Curriculum Standards for Compulsory Education* to incorporate elements of socialist and revolutionary culture, Chinese traditions, national security, and health education, thereby aligning EFL education more closely with broader state educational and ideological objectives (MOE, 2022b).

During this period, teaching and assessment materials devoted to the expression of Chinese culture in English became more visible in the EFL sector. In the CET-4 and CET-6 exams, the English-to-Chinese translation section was removed, leaving only Chinese-to-English translation, with topics focused on Chinese history, culture, economy and social development (National College English Testing Committee, 2013). This change can be understood as aligning with the broader policy discourse of improving students' ability to "tell China's story well" (Xi, 2014). The *Understanding Contemporary China* textbook series in colleges and universities published by the Foreign Language Teaching and Research Press also highlights promoting Chinese culture and fostering confidence among

Chinese youth (Foreign Language Teaching and Research Press, 2022). Moreover, contests on intercultural competence or English speech competitions were frequently organized, with themes often centered on telling stories about China.

During this period, Chinese EFL scholarship continued to engage with international pedagogical trends while also placing greater emphasis on locally developed approaches. The MOE (2018b) introduced China's Standards of English Language Ability, which set out clear proficiency levels for various stages of EFL education in China. One prominent example is the Production-Oriented Approach (POA), proposed by Wen (2015, 2020), by emphasizing output-driven, input-enabled learning through the cycle of "motivating–enabling–assessing". POA has received considerable attention in teaching practice, textbook design and academic discussion within China, and is often cited as an example of attempts to articulate pedagogical frameworks grounded in the Chinese context.

At the same time, however, this period also witnessed a noticeable reevaluation of the social and educational status of English in China, as reflected in examination reform and the restructuring of the private tutoring sector. The mid-2010s Gaokao English reform pilots introduced the idea of multiple testing opportunities and reduced the dominance of a single high-stakes English examination, thereby suggesting a more diversified understanding of English within the broader educational system (State Council, 2014). This tendency became even more pronounced after the *2021 Double Reduction* policy, which drastically reshaped the ecology of off-campus subject tutoring, including the once-expansive English training sector (General Office of the CPC Central Committee & General Office of the State Council, 2021). In line with these shifts, the role of SRLL applications in China's education system has grown significantly. Lo and Chang (2025) observe that SRLL through mobile-assisted language learning is increasingly shaping how learners interact with language learning apps, which are now influenced not only by individual choice but also by platform governance, resource curation, and institutional guidelines. In this evolving landscape, institutions have increasingly integrated Positive Psychology (PP) interventions, such as mindfulness and gratitude practices, into professional development (PD) programs to support teacher well-being and foster a supportive educational environment. These institution-led initiatives are part of a broader shift in higher education EFL, focusing on enhancing teacher support and resilience as key components of educational quality (Lo and Chang, 2025).

AI-enabled foreign language education also emerged as a new feature of this period. In recent years, the Chinese government has adopted a proactive approach to integrating AI innovations into education. Key initiatives, such as the *2017 New Generation Artificial Intelligence Development Plan* and the *2018 Action Plan for Artificial Intelligence Innovation in Higher Education* (MOE, 2018a), reflect this commitment. In 2024, the MOE issued the *Notice of the General Office on Strengthening Artificial Intelligence Education in Primary and Secondary Schools* (MOE, 2024), followed by the *2025 Opinions on Accelerating the Digitalization of Education* (MOE, 2025). Rather than providing detailed EFL-specific policy directives, these documents are better understood as establishing a broader policy environment for educational digitalization and technological innovation, which has in turn encouraged the gradual adoption of AI in EFL education. At the same time, the rise of generative AI has also intensified debate about the future of English majors in higher education. In this broader context, a number of universities have suspended enrollment in or discontinued English-related programs. In 2023, the University of Science and Technology of China—a top university—formally discontinued its English major (USTC, 2023). This was followed by multiple institutions, including Shenyang Aerospace University (suspending English enrollment in 2024), East China Normal University (suspending Translation in 2025), and Shanghai University of Finance and Economics (suspending English enrollment in 2025) (ECNU, 2025; SAU, 2024; SUFE, 2025).

Taken as a whole, the Reform and Opening-up Period witnessed major changes in EFL education in China. Policy management progressively institutionalized English across primary, secondary, and tertiary education through curriculum reform, teacher training, national testing, and expanding local and national policy arrangements. At the level of beliefs, English evolved from a primarily instrumental resource for modernization, science, and economic development into a broader vehicle for intercultural competence, global engagement, and, more recently, the international communication of Chinese culture and national interests. In practice, English learning expanded on a very large scale, but it remained shaped by regional inequality, school stratification, market demand, and technological change. This period therefore saw English move from a restricted educational subject into a mass educational and social resource with increasingly complex national functions; at the same time, in its later phase, English was also gradually repositioned in response to concerns over student burden, educational equity, the growing importance of SRLL in digital learning, teacher well-being, and the emerging impact of AI on language education and the social value of English.

7 Discussion

7.1 A tripartite reading of historical change

Viewed through Spolsky's tripartite framework, the history of EFL policy in China is best understood not as a linear story of expansion, but as a changing relationship among language management, language beliefs/ideology, and language practices across different historical periods. Spolsky (2004) argues that language policy consists not only of explicit management, but also of the beliefs that legitimize language choices and the practices through which those choices are enacted or constrained. This perspective is particularly useful for the Chinese case, where policy documents alone cannot fully explain either the rapid expansion or the repeated disruption of English education. Table 2 provides a more fine-grained periodization within these broader historical phases, showing how language management, language beliefs/ideology, and language practices shifted across different stages of China's EFL policy. Table 3 further complements this by chronicling the major macro-political events backdrop against which these shifts unfolded.

During the Semi-colonial Period (1862–1949), language management remained limited in scale but became increasingly

TABLE 2. Historical shifts in language management, language beliefs/ideology, and language practices in China's EFL policy.

Historical period	Language management	Language beliefs/ideology	Language practices
1862–1912 (Beginning of Modernity)	Government-supported foreign language schools; use of English in diplomacy, self-strengthening and trade	An instrument for acquiring Western science and technology; Zhong Ti Xi Yong (Chinese learning for fundamental principles, Western learning for practical application); sensitivity to preserving Chinese nationality	Limited to coastal areas; focused on translation of official documents or notes
1912–1949 (Republican Era)	Ministry of Education issued curriculum guidelines; fluctuating policies due to political instability	Internationalization coexisting with nationalist concerns; English associated with modernization	Expansion of English in secondary and higher education; introduction of English culture and literature in some elite schools
1949–1966 (Early PRC)	State-directed replacement of English with Russian in curricula; marginalization of English in national exams	Russian promoted as the language of socialist solidarity; English marginalized and viewed with political suspicion	Decline of English teaching; Russian became dominant in foreign language education
1966–1976 (Cultural Revolution)	Political campaigns overrode educational planning; foreign language education was heavily politized and often suspended or distorted	English linked to "capitalist" ideology; revolutionary ideology overshadowed pedagogical concerns	Severe disruption of English teaching; politically charged content; limited authentic exposure to language and culture
1978–1989 (Revival)	Strong state promotion of English through curriculum reform, teacher-training programs, Gaokao English and CET-4/6; selective support for elite and key schools	Utilitarian characteristics; perceived as a tool of modernization, science, technology and economic growth	Rebuilding teacher resources; restoration of English in schools and universities; increasing emphasis on examination performance and efficiency
1989–2012 (Flourishing)	Globalization of EFL policies; standardization; encouragement of intercultural competence and learner autonomy	Linguistic capital for personal career development; shift from instrument-oriented to culture-oriented	Rapid expansion of English learning in schools, universities, and society; overseas study boom; dumb English
2012–2025 (Global Engagement)	Reevaluation of the status of English education and mother tongue education; emphasis on Chinese cultural elements in foreign language education; promotion of AI integration in EFL teaching	Cultural confidence; making China's voice heard globally; bolstering soft power; instrumental/humanistic/political values	Competency-driven; POA; AI-powered EFL education; intercultural teaching practice; learning for communication

visible through the establishment of foreign language schools, curriculum arrangements, and support for diplomatic and educational initiatives. Language beliefs in this period were largely instrumental: English was valued as a means of diplomacy, trade, military strengthening, and access to Western knowledge. At the same time, such beliefs were constrained by a strong concern for preserving Chinese cultural foundations, as reflected in formulations such as *Zhong Ti Xi Yong*. In practice, English learning remained socially restricted, translation-oriented, and concentrated among urban elites. Thus, management, beliefs, and practices were broadly aligned around a pragmatic but cautious acceptance of English, although actual access remained narrow.

The Communist Revolution Period (1949–1978) reveals a far less stable relationship among these three dimensions. In the early PRC, language management shifted sharply with geopolitical realignment, as Russian replaced English as the dominant foreign language under the influence of Sino-Soviet relations. English was not merely downgraded institutionally; it was also ideologically reframed, and at certain moments became politically suspect. Here, ideologies about foreign languages were shaped less by pedagogy than by class politics, socialist solidarity, and revolutionary discourse. In practice, English teaching declined, teacher resources contracted, and curriculum content became heavily politicized. Although the late 1950s and early 1960s saw attempts to restore English in response to changing diplomatic needs, these efforts were repeatedly interrupted by political campaigns and ultimately devastated during the Cultural Revolution. This period therefore illustrates not only policy reversal, but also a striking divergence between political management and sustainable educational practice.

The Reform and Opening-up Period (1978–2025) marks the large-scale institutionalization and social expansion of EFL education in China. At the level of management, English was progressively embedded across primary, secondary, and tertiary education through curriculum reform, teacher training, national examinations, textbook reform, and the increasing involvement of local authorities and market actors. At the level of beliefs/ideology, English first re-emerged as an instrumental resource for modernization, science, technology, and economic growth, but later acquired broader meanings associated with communicative competence, intercultural awareness, global engagement, and, more recently, the international communication of Chinese culture and national interests. In practice, English learning expanded on an unprecedented scale, extending beyond elite

TABLE 3. Major macro-political events and corresponding key EFL policies/documents in China's EFL development.

Macro-Political Events	Key EFL Policies/Documents	Historical period
Self-Strengthening Movement (1861–1895)	Tongwen Guan established (1862) Shanghai Multi-language School (1863) Guangzhou Tung Wen College (1864) Hubei Self-improvement School (1893)	Semi-colonial Period
	1903 School System (1902–1904)	
Republic of China established (1912)	New School System (1912) University Regulations (1913) Rules for Implementation of Higher Primary Schools (1916) Outline of Foreign Language Curriculum for Junior Middle Schools (1923) Outline of Foreign Language Curriculum for Senior High Schools (1923) Interim English Curriculum Standards for Junior/Senior Middle Schools (1929)	
Founding of PRC (1949)	Russian dominance policy (1949–1956)	Communist Revolution Period
Sino-Soviet Treaty of Friendship (1950)	English courses suspended in junior middle schools (1954)	
Anti-rightist Movement (1957) Sino-Soviet Split (1960)	English introduced from first year of high school (1956) Senior High School English Syllabus (Draft) (1956) Junior High School English Syllabus (Draft) (1957) Notice on Strengthening Foreign Language Education (1959) Outline of Seven-year Plan for Foreign Language Education (1964)	
Cultural Revolution (1966–1976)	EFL education suspended (1966–1976)	
Reform and Opening-up launched (1978)	Suggestions on Strengthening Foreign Language Education (SISU, 1978) English reinstated in Gaokao (1978)	
Removal of leftist ideologies (1980) Shanghai CTMRC established WTO accession (2001)	Public English Syllabus for Science and Engineering (1980, updated 1985) Three-year College English Teachers Training Program (1980–1983) MOE crafts English syllabus for six prestigious schools (1982) College English Syllabus for Arts and Science (1986) College English Test-4 (CET-4) introduced (1986) College English Test-6 (CET-6) introduced (1987) National secondary English syllabuses revised (1992, 1993, 1996) Opinions on Reform of Foreign Language Majors (1998) College English Syllabus revision (1999) Syllabus for English Majors (2000) Guidance on Actively Promoting English in Primary Schools (2001) General Senior High School Curriculum Standards (2003)	Reform and Opening-up Period
China becomes world's second-largest economy (2010)	College English Teaching Guidelines (2016) General Senior High School Curriculum Standards (2017, 2020 revision) China's Standards of English Proficiency (CSE) (2018) Guidelines for English Majors (2020) English Curriculum Standards for Compulsory Education (2022)	
AI and digital revolution (2010s–2020s)	New Generation AI Development Plan (2017) AI Innovation in Higher Education Action Plan (2018) Notice on Strengthening AI Education in Primary/Secondary Schools (2024) Opinions on Accelerating Digitalization of Education (2025)	

schools into mass schooling, private training, overseas study, and digitally mediated learning. Yet this expansion also produced persistent tensions, including regional inequality, examination pressure, "dumb English", uneven teacher quality, and, more recently, new uncertainties associated with AI and changing labor-market demand. This period therefore reflects not simply policy success, but a growing complexity in the interaction between policy ambition and educational reality.

7.2 Enduring patterns in China's EFL policy

First, EFL policy in China has consistently been tied to nation-building. English has rarely been legitimized as culturally neutral or educationally autonomous. Rather, it has been repeatedly assigned national functions. In the late Qing, it served self-strengthening and diplomatic survival; in the Republican era, it became linked to modernization and educational development;

in the early PRC, it was subordinated to socialist alignment and revolutionary ideology; in the Reform era, it became central to modernization and globalization; and in the contemporary period, it is increasingly associated with cultural confidence and soft power. English, once viewed purely as an instrumental tool for modernization, is now increasingly linked to China's global image and international discourse. As Xi (2014) has emphasized, "Cultural confidence is a more fundamental, profound, and lasting strength". Additionally, "enhancing the country's soft power through cultural exchange is key to increasing international influence" (Xinhua News Agency, 2024). This continuity strongly supports Spolsky's (2004) view that language beliefs/ideology are central to language policy, because they shape not only whether a language is promoted, but also what social meanings and political purposes are attached to it.

Second, the Chinese case reveals the enduring importance of top-down language management. Major shifts in EFL policy were usually initiated by the state or by influential political leaders, and then implemented through curriculum standards, school systems, examinations, teacher-education programs, or local administrative adaptation. This centralized pattern enabled China to scale up English education rapidly, especially after 1978, but it also made the system highly sensitive to larger ideological and political shifts. In this sense, China's EFL policy history illustrates Spolsky's (2009) observation that "language policy is all about choices": choices made by authorities are never isolated educational decisions, but are embedded in broader struggles over development priorities, geopolitical orientation, and national identity.

Third, the Chinese case highlights a persistent gap between language management and language practices. Even when policy strongly supported English, access to effective EFL education varied significantly by region, school type, urban-rural location, and teacher availability. Coastal cities, elite schools, and economically developed regions benefited earlier and more deeply from EFL reforms, whereas less developed areas often lagged behind. This unevenness shows that language practice cannot be inferred directly from policy rhetoric. Rather, practice reflects the material and institutional conditions under which policy is enacted. In this respect, China's experience aligns closely with Spolsky's ecological understanding of language policy, in which actual language practices may support, modify, or constrain official management.

A further pattern is that EFL policy in China has repeatedly oscillated between relatively narrow instrumentalism and broader cultural or ideological agendas. During the early Reform era, English was promoted primarily as a tool for modernization and economic growth. However, the pedagogical limitations of this orientation, including exam-oriented teaching and "dumb English", gradually led policymakers to incorporate communicative competence, learner autonomy, intercultural awareness, and teacher development into policy discourse. The MOE (2020a) highlighted that "cultivating students with the ability to learn independently is one of the core goals of educational reform", which reflects a shift towards empowering learners in the English language classroom. This move towards autonomy reflects a deeper ideological shift. Where English is not merely seen as a tool for economic or instrumental purposes, but as part of broader educational reforms aimed at nurturing independent, critical thinkers. As Pan (2015) argues, EFL education in China has remained ideologically loaded, simultaneously promoting global engagement while also participating in the construction of national identity and modernization discourses. More recently, these goals have been supplemented by a stronger emphasis on Chinese cultural expression, moral education, and national security. This shift does not mean that instrumentalism disappeared; rather, the ideological content attached to English became more layered. English remained useful, but the definition of its usefulness changed over time.

7.3 The explanatory value of Spolsky's framework

The relationship among management, beliefs/ideology, and practices in China's EFL policy has never been fixed. In some periods, the three dimensions were broadly aligned, as when English was widely understood as useful for national development and was institutionally promoted. In other periods, they were sharply misaligned, as during the Cultural Revolution, when language management discouraged English, ideological beliefs rendered it politically problematic, and classroom practice was distorted by political extremism. This confirms Spolsky's (2004) central claim that language policy cannot be reduced to official decrees alone, but must also be traced in language beliefs and in actual institutional and learner practices. This analysis therefore moves beyond descriptive historical narration and beyond explanations that attribute policy shifts solely to changing state needs or national interests. Instead, it shows that the evolution of China's EFL policy is better understood as a historically contingent process shaped by the interaction among language management, language beliefs/ideology, and language practices.

The Chinese case not only substantiates Spolsky's argument that language policy emerges from the interaction of management, beliefs/ideology, and practices, but also suggests more specifically that the degree of alignment among these dimensions has important consequences for policy implementation. More specifically, policy implementation becomes especially effective when top-down language management converges with bottom-up social beliefs. This analytical perspective is especially valuable because it moves beyond treating policy as a sequence of official documents and instead highlights the social conditions under which reform gains momentum. The rapid revival of EFL education after Reform and Opening-up, for example, reflected not only renewed state support but also a widespread belief that English provided access to knowledge, opportunity, and the outside world. The Chinese case thus suggests that when formal management and popular beliefs are aligned, language policy is more likely to be rapidly institutionalized and broadly supported.

Beyond explaining variation in policy implementation, the Chinese case also shows that Spolsky's framework can illuminate a deeper historical continuity in the strategic function of foreign language policy despite dramatic shifts in ideological content. Across different periods, English moved from being a tool of diplomacy and self-strengthening, to a politically suspect language, to a resource for modernization, and then to a medium for global communication and the international articulation of Chinese culture. Yet throughout these

transformations, English remained closely tied to state projects of national development and China's changing self-positioning in the world. The policy history of EFL in China is therefore best understood not as a simple story of educational modernization, but as a historically layered process shaped by the ongoing negotiation among what the state manages, what society believes, and what institutions and learners can actually sustain in practice.

8 Conclusion

Applying Spolsky's tripartite framework to China's EFL policy history allows this study to move beyond mere description and explain why English has been alternately promoted, restricted, repoliticized, and refunctionalized over time. The framework not only clarifies the interaction among language management, beliefs/ideology, and practices in China, but also highlights enduring tensions, continuities, and transformations in modern EFL education.

In terms of language management, policymakers should align high-stakes assessment systems with stated communicative goals, reducing the backwash effect that privileges rote learning. Establishing clear AI integration guidelines at the policy level is also critical, ensuring that technological tools enhance rather than undermine pedagogy and assessment. These measures help assessments and technologies directly support the intended learning outcomes, fostering genuine communicative competence. Moreover, institutional leadership should allocate resources for PP-informed professional PD to provide essential support for teacher well-being.

Regarding language beliefs/ideology, targeted initiatives should recalibrate public and professional expectations. This includes teacher PD that reframes communicative competence as a realistic outcome, alongside public discourse efforts to counter entrenched examination-centric views. Teacher well-being should be reframed as integral to the quality and equity of education, ensuring that policies support teachers in maintaining resilience and positive classroom engagement. AI literacy should also be incorporated into such initiatives, helping teachers and communities understand AI's role as a pedagogical supplement rather than a substitute.

For language practices, resources and support should be strategically concentrated in under-resourced regions, including targeted teacher training, infrastructure investment, and monitoring mechanisms. To enhance learning outcomes, it is crucial to develop SRLL-aligned curricular scaffolds, provide teacher training on SRLL orchestration, and establish approved resource banks to ensure equitable access to high-quality, institutionally curated learning tools. AI tools should be introduced alongside PD to ensure equitable access and effective use across diverse educational contexts. Furthermore, teachers should be allocated protected time to fully engage in training programs, and monitoring implementation fidelity is crucial to ensure the successful integration of the strategies outlined above.

Future research could build on the present study by exploring how EFL policy in China interacts with the broader language-in-education ecology, particularly the parallel agendas of Putonghua and minority-language education, the regulatory restructuring of the private tutoring sector since 2021, and the growing significance of EMI in higher education. By addressing these challenges through coordinated actions across management, beliefs/ideology, and practices, China can continue to strengthen both the efficacy and social inclusivity of its EFL education system.

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Generative AI statement

The author declares that generative AI was used in the creation of this manuscript. The authors used ChatGPT (OpenAI) and DeepSeek solely for language polishing and stylistic refinement. All content, data interpretation, and scientific conclusions remain the responsibility of the authors; no generative AI output was incorporated without critical review and verification.

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Appendix Key ministry of education and state policy documents

Year	Document title	Source/URL
1956	*The Notice on the Discipline of Foreign Languages in Middle Schools* (MOE)	http://politics.people.com.cn/n1/2019/1107/c429373-31443185.html
1978	*Suggestions on Strengthening Foreign Language Education* (SISU)	People Education, *11*, 28-30 (no URL available)
1991	*Achievement of Education in China 1986*–1990 (SEC)	Beijing: People's Education Press (no URL available)
2001	*Guidance on Actively Promoting English Education in Primary Schools* (MOE)	http://www.moe.gov.cn/s78/A26/jces_left/moe_714/tnull_665.html
2003	*General Senior High School Curriculum Standards* (MOE)	https://www.moe.gov.cn/srcsite/A26/s8001/200303/t20030331_167349.html
2013	Explanation of Adjustments to the CET-4 and CET-6 Test Formats (NCETC)	https://jwc.wzu.edu.cn/info/1081/4705.htm
2017	*General Senior High School Curriculum Standards* (MOE)	https://www.moe.gov.cn/srcsite/A26/s8001/201801/t20180115_324647.html
2018	*Action Plan for Artificial Intelligence Innovation in Higher Education Institutions* (MOE)	https://www.moe.gov.cn/srcsite/A16/s7062/201804/t20180410_332722.html
2018	*China's Standards of English Language Ability* (MOE)	https://www.moe.gov.cn/srcsite/A19/s229/201804/t20180416_333315.html
2018	*National Standard for Teaching Quality of Foreign Language and Literature* (MOE)	https://www.moe.gov.cn/jyb_xwfb/xw_fbh/moe_2069/xwfbh_2018n/xwfb_20180130_325920.html
2020	*College English Teaching Guidelines* (MOE)	https://www.jyb.cn/rmtzcg/xwy/wzxw/202010/t20201021_367148.html
2020	*General Senior High School Curriculum Standards* (MOE)	https://www.moe.gov.cn/srcsite/A26/s8001/202006/t20200603_462199.html
2020	*Guidelines for English Majors* (MOE)	https://sfl.hbeu.edu.cn/info/1088/8715.htm
2022	*Artificial Intelligence Promotes Educational Transformation and Innovation* (MOE)	https://www.moe.gov.cn/jyb_xwfb/s5148/202212/t20221222_1035689.html
2022	*English Curriculum Standards for Compulsory Education* (MOE)	https://www.moe.gov.cn/srcsite/A26/s8001/202204/t20220420_619921.html
2023	*Notice on Undergraduate Program Registration and Approval* (MOE)	https://www.moe.gov.cn/s78/A08/tongzhi/202307/t20230718_1069559.html
2023	*Plan for the Optimization and Reform of Higher Education Disciplines* (MOE)	https://www.moe.gov.cn/srcsite/A08/s7056/202304/t20230404_1054230.html
2024	*Minister of Education: AI Empowering Education* (MOE)	https://www.moe.gov.cn/jyb_xwfb/ew_zt/moe_357/2024/2024_zt02/mtbd/202402/t20240202_1114004.html